

Christianity as a Catalyst for Governance-Oriented Development
in Africa: A Qualitative Study of Church Leaders and
Faith-Based Development Practitioners

Research Proposal

Group 4

International School of Ministry (ISM)

Christian Research Methodology (CRM)

Faith-Based Research and Proposal

Writing

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Deepest Appreciation:

Thank you for making time for this conversation. We know your schedule is demanding, and we genuinely appreciate you creating space for us out of your busy commitments. Your experience and insight are invaluable to this research, and we're honored to learn from leaders who are shaping industries and communities in Africa. We'll keep this session focused and respectful of your time. Thank you again for your openness and for contributing to this work.

Preamble

This study explores the role of Christianity as a catalyst for governance-oriented development across sub-Saharan Africa. Rather than relying solely on theory, we are documenting the lived experiences and practical insights of those doing the work on the ground, church leaders and faith-based development practitioners who are navigating the intersection of faith, leadership, and public life. Your perspective is central to this research. As leaders who understand both the realities of ministry and the demands of development, your reflections will help us capture what is actually working, where the challenges lie, and how faith communities can contribute more effectively to governance and societal progress. All insights shared will be handled with confidentiality and used strictly for research and developmental purposes. Attribution will only be made with your prior consent.

Abstract

This study examines how Christianity functions as a catalyst for governance-oriented development in sub-Saharan Africa, focusing on the lived experiences and perspectives of church leaders and faith-based development practitioners. While existing scholarship documents Christianity's contributions to education, healthcare, and social welfare, its role in governance-oriented development, specifically through ethical leadership formation, civic education, anti-corruption advocacy, institutional accountability, and peacebuilding, remains undertheorized and empirically underexplored. This qualitative study addresses that gap through semi-structured, in-depth interviews with purposively selected participants across Ghana, Nigeria, Zimbabwe, South Africa, and Kenya. Guided by an integrated theoretical framework drawing on transformational development theory, public theology, and institutional theory, the study asks how Christianity strengthens or weakens development through governance engagement and under what conditions Christian institutions can move beyond welfare provision to drive structural transformation. Data are analyzed using Braun & Clarke's (2022) six-phase thematic analysis, managed through Dedoose, a web-based qualitative data analysis platform. The study observes rigorous ethical standards, including informed consent, confidentiality, and researcher reflexivity. Findings will contribute to a contextually grounded, governance-oriented framework for Christian institutional engagement in African development, advancing scholarship at the intersection of African Christianity, development studies, and public theology.

Keywords: Christianity, governance, development, Africa, qualitative research, public theology, transformational development, institutional accountability, ethical leadership, civic education

Appendix A

Interview Guide

Study Title

Christianity as a Catalyst for Governance-Oriented Development in Africa: A Qualitative Study of Church Leaders and Faith-Based Development Practitioners

Purpose

This interview explores your experiences and perspectives on how Christianity contributes to governance-oriented development in sub-Saharan Africa. There are no right or wrong answers. Your honest account, including your experience of both successes and limitations, is what matters most. The interview will last approximately 60 to 90 minutes. With your consent, it will be audio-recorded for transcription purposes only. You may decline to answer any question at any time.

Section 1: Background and Context

1. Can you briefly describe your role and how long you have served in leadership within your institution or organisation?
2. How would you describe the development context in which your church or organisation currently operates?
3. In your own words, what do you understand by “development” and “governance”? How do these concepts relate to your ministry or work?

Section 2: Christianity and Development

4. In your experience, in what ways has Christianity contributed to development in your community or country?

Probes: What do you see as the most significant contributions? How sustainable have they been?

What conditions have made them more or less effective?

5. How has Christianity's role in development changed over the past ten to twenty years in your context?

Section 3: Governance Engagement in Practice

6. How does your church or organisation currently engage with issues of governance, corruption, civic education, or public accountability?

Probes: Can you give specific examples? Who is involved? What forms does this engagement take?

7. In your view, what is the appropriate role of the Christian church in governance and political life? Where do you draw the boundary between appropriate engagement and inappropriate entanglement?
8. Can you describe a specific instance where Christian leadership made a meaningful contribution to governance or accountability in your context? What made it effective?
9. Can you describe a situation where the church failed to engage governance challenges effectively? What do you think went wrong?

Section 4: Leadership Formation and Civic Education

10. How does your church or organisation invest in developing ethical and accountable leaders, both for the church and for public life?

Probes: Do you have specific programmes? What theological or practical frameworks do you use?

How do you assess whether leadership formation is working?

11. Does your church provide any form of civic education to its congregation or the broader community? If so, what does this look like in practice?

12. In your view, what should theological education be equipping future leaders to do in relation to governance and public life? Is this happening in your context?

Section 5: Internal Contradictions and Limitations

13. Are there ways in which Christianity, including specific theological positions or institutional practices, has hindered rather than helped development or governance engagement in your context?

Probes: How do you reflect on the prosperity gospel in relation to development? What about leadership accountability within the church itself?

14. What do you see as the biggest obstacles preventing Christian institutions from being more effective partners in governance and development in Africa?

15. How do you think your own church or organisation could improve its engagement with governance and accountability, both internally and externally?

Section 6: Conditions for Structural Transformation

16. In your experience, what conditions need to be in place for a Christian institution to move beyond providing services and begin to drive structural change in governance and development?
17. What would a credible, governance-oriented framework for Christian institutional engagement in African development look like to you? What would it need to include?
18. Is there anything else you would like to add about Christianity's role in development and governance in Africa that we have not yet covered?

Closing: Thank you sincerely for your time and your openness. Your account will contribute meaningfully to this research. We will share the findings with you upon completion of the study.

If you have any questions or concerns after today, please do not hesitate to contact us.

Once again, Thank You for your time despite your extremely busy schedule.

Appendix B

Participant Information Sheet

Study Title

Christianity as a Catalyst for Governance-Oriented Development in Africa: A Qualitative Study of Church Leaders and Faith-Based Development Practitioners

Who is Conducting This Study?

This study is conducted by Group 4 students at the International School of Ministry (ISM) as part of the Master of Arts in Ministry programme, under academic supervision.

What Is the Study About?

This study examines how Christianity contributes to governance-oriented development in sub-Saharan Africa, specifically through ethical leadership formation, civic education, anti-corruption advocacy, institutional accountability, and peacebuilding. We are seeking the perspectives of experienced church leaders and faith-based development practitioners.

Why Are You Being Invited?

You are being invited because of your senior leadership experience within a Christian institution or faith-based development organisation in one of the five selected countries. Your perspectives are directly relevant to the research questions.

What Will Participation Involve?

If you agree to participate, you will take part in a single in-depth interview lasting approximately 60 to 90 minutes.. The interview will be conducted in person or via a secure, encrypted video-

conferencing platform at a time and location convenient to you. With your consent, the interview will be audio-recorded for the purpose of transcription only.

Is Participation Voluntary?

Participation is entirely voluntary. You are free to withdraw at any time, without providing reasons and without any negative consequence. If you withdraw, any data collected from you up to that point will be deleted.

How Will Your Information Be Kept Confidential?

Your identity will be protected at all times. You will be assigned a pseudonym, and any identifying details will be removed from transcripts and published findings. Audio recordings will be stored on encrypted, password-protected devices accessible only to the research team and will be deleted upon completion of the study. No identifying information will be shared with any third party.

What Are the Benefits and Risks?

There are no direct personal benefits to you from participating, though your contribution will advance understanding of Christianity's governance-oriented developmental role in Africa. The study presents minimal risk. Topics discussed, including governance, corruption, and institutional accountability, may be sensitive in some contexts. You are under no obligation to answer any question that makes you uncomfortable, and you may end the interview at any point.

What Happens Next?

If you are willing to participate, please complete and return the attached Informed Consent Form. We will then contact you to arrange the interview. Upon completion of the study, findings will be shared with participating institutions in an accessible summary format.

Contact

If you have any questions about the study before or after the interview, please contact the research team at;

+234 916 256 5436 Sharon

+1 (240) 758-1292 Ayo

Appendix C

Informed Consent Form

Study Title

Christianity as a Catalyst for Governance-Oriented Development in Africa: A Qualitative Study of Church Leaders and Faith-Based Development Practitioners

Please read each statement carefully and initial the box beside each one to indicate your agreement. Then sign and date the form at the bottom.

1. I have read and understood the Participant Information Sheet for this study. Initial: _____
2. I have had the opportunity to ask questions, and any questions I had were answered to my satisfaction. Initial: _____
3. I understand that my participation is entirely voluntary and that I may withdraw at any time without providing reasons and without any negative consequence. Initial: _____
4. I understand that if I withdraw, any data collected from me up to that point will be deleted. Initial: _____
5. I understand that my identity will be protected through the use of a pseudonym and that no identifying information will appear in any published findings. Initial: _____
6. I consent to the interview being audio-recorded for transcription purposes. Initial: _____

7. I understand that audio recordings will be stored securely and deleted upon completion of the study. Initial: _____

8. I agree to participate in this study. Initial: _____

Participant Name (print): _____

Participant Signature: _____

Date: _____

Institution or Organisation: _____

Country: _____

Interviewer Name: _____

Interviewer Signature: _____

Date: _____